

Chapter Fourteen

The Door She Left Closed

Maya did not ask Nora to explain immediately.

That was mercy.

Instead, she made coffee.

Bad coffee, because Maya had always treated measurements as suggestions and patience as a luxury. She poured too much into two chipped mugs, added milk to Nora's without asking, and set both on the table beside a plate of toast that was too dark around the edges.

The morning looked almost ordinary.

That made it harder.

Nora sat on the couch with one blanket around her shoulders and another twisted around her knees. Her neck ached from sleeping upright. Her eyes burned. The apartment smelled of coffee, rain, and the lemon soap Maya used in the shower.

Maya sat across from her on the floor, mug between both hands.

"You stayed out," Maya said at last.

Nora looked down.

"Yes."

"What does that mean exactly?"

Nora rubbed her thumb along the seam of the blanket. "Last night, after you went to bed, I felt something. Pressure. Not strong, but enough. I think it was coming from you."

Maya's face tightened.

Nora saw the fear and forced herself not to rush.

"I didn't follow it," she said.

Maya stared at her.

“I wanted to,” Nora admitted. “Not because I wanted to know your secrets. Because I heard something. Or felt something. I thought you might be crying. Or having a nightmare. I thought maybe you needed me.”

“I did have a nightmare,” Maya said quietly.

Nora closed her eyes.

The old instinct woke.

Ask what it was.

Ask if it was about her father.

Ask if Adam was in it.

Ask if Nora herself had become something frightening inside Maya’s mind.

She did not ask.

Maya watched the battle pass across her face.

“You’re trying very hard not to question me.”

“Yes.”

“Does it hurt?”

Nora gave a small, exhausted laugh. “Like holding my breath.”

Maya’s expression softened.

Then, unexpectedly, she smiled.

“That sounds healthy.”

“It sounds ridiculous.”

“It sounds like progress.”

Nora looked at her.

Maya's smile faded into something more serious. "Thank you."

The words were simple.

They broke Nora more than accusation might have.

"For doing nothing?" Nora asked.

"For letting nothing be enough."

Nora looked away quickly.

The room blurred.

Maya moved closer, then stopped herself halfway.

The restraint was clumsy.

Beautiful.

Nora noticed and understood.

They were both learning how not to enter each other too quickly.

After breakfast, Maya called her mother.

Nora went into the bathroom and turned on the tap so she would not hear. She washed her face slowly, then brushed her teeth with the spare toothbrush Maya kept for her in the cup by the sink. The toothbrush was purple. Maya had bought it years ago, declaring that Nora was "spiritually a purple toothbrush person."

Nora had argued.

Then kept using it.

She stared at it now, a small ordinary proof of being expected somewhere.

From beyond the bathroom door, Maya's voice rose once. Not anger exactly. Strain.

Nora gripped the sink.

No pressure came.

Only the desire to go out and make the voice softer.

She stayed where she was.

When she returned to the living room, Maya was standing by the window, phone lowered in one hand.

“My father wants to see you,” Maya said.

Nora stopped.

“What?”

“He asked about you. Mom told him I was with you. He said, ‘Bring the dramatic one.’”

Nora blinked.

Maya smiled faintly. “That means he likes you.”

“I’ve met him twice.”

“He has strong instincts.”

“He called me dramatic?”

“He calls everyone dramatic. Last week he called a nurse dramatic for asking him to stop walking around with an IV pole like a weapon.”

Nora laughed before she could stop herself.

The laugh warmed the room.

Then reality returned.

“You’re sure?” Nora asked.

Maya leaned against the window frame. “I’m sure he asked. I’m not sure I’m ready.”

“Then we wait.”

Maya’s eyes moved over her face, searching for resentment, panic, eagerness, anything Nora might make her manage.

Nora held still beneath the searching.

“I mean it,” she said. “We wait.”

Maya nodded slowly.

“I think I want you there tomorrow,” she said. “Not the whole day. Just visiting hours. No research. No medical questions unless he starts it. No trying to become the emotional project manager of my family.”

Nora lifted one hand. “I swear.”

“Do not swear. You take swearing very seriously and then look haunted if you fail.”

“That is painfully accurate.”

“Say you’ll try.”

“I’ll try.”

Maya nodded. “Good.”

The word made Nora unexpectedly nervous.

Tomorrow.

The hospital.

Tomas Santos, no longer a memory glimpsed through Adam, but a person who had asked for her by name.

Given, not taken.

She held on to that.

When Nora left Maya’s apartment, the sky had cleared into a bright, washed-out blue. The city looked too clean after the rain, all the hard edges shining. People hurried along the pavement with paper cups, phones, dogs, flowers, groceries, ordinary burdens.

Nora tried not to imagine the weather beneath their faces.

She made it almost two blocks before her phone rang.

Adam.

“Hi,” she said.

“Hi. How was last night?”

Nora smiled faintly. “That sounds like a question with twelve smaller questions hiding behind it.”

“It is.”

“I stayed over. Maya slept. I slept badly. Nothing happened.”

“Nothing?”

“Almost something.”

Adam went quiet.

Nora stopped beside a shop window full of lamps. Her reflection stood among them, pale and tired but upright.

“I felt pressure,” she said. “From Maya, I think. But I didn’t follow it.”

Adam exhaled.

The sound was full of relief and something like awe.

“Nora.”

“Please don’t make it huge.”

“It is huge.”

“It felt like sitting on a couch and panicking in the dark.”

“Sometimes that is what huge looks like.”

Nora closed her eyes briefly.

She loved him.

That remained true beneath everything.

Maybe that was part of the injustice too. Love did not disappear just because it became difficult. It stayed and demanded better architecture.

“Maya wants me to visit her father tomorrow,” Nora said.

Adam was quiet for half a beat too long.

Nora opened her eyes.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“Adam.”

“I’m glad.”

“You paused.”

“I was thinking.”

“About what?”

He exhaled. “About whether you’re ready.”

Irritation sparked. “Maya asked me.”

“I know.”

“Her father asked me.”

“I know.”

“Then ready according to whom?”

The silence tightened.

Adam said softly, “According to the person who threw up after entering a stranger’s grief. According to the person who almost collapsed in a library yesterday. According to the person I love and keep watching get hurt.”

The irritation faltered.

But did not vanish.

“That sounds like concern,” Nora said.

“It is concern.”

“It also sounds like doubt.”

Adam did not deny it.

The honesty hurt more than argument.

“You don’t think I should go.”

“I think you should go if Maya wants you there and if you can go as Nora, not as someone trying to prove she can be trusted.”

The words struck the exact place she had hidden from herself.

Nora looked at her reflection in the lamp-shop window.

Was that what this was?

A chance to prove she could be good.

Safe.

Invited.

Not a thief.

“I can do both,” she said.

“Can you?”

The question was not cruel.

It still felt like a verdict.

Nora’s voice cooled. “I’ll talk to you later.”

“Nora—”

She ended the call.

For a few seconds, she stood motionless with the phone in her hand.

Then she saw her reflection clearly.

A woman angry because someone had doubted her.

A woman angrier because the doubt had reason.

She wanted to throw the phone into the street.

Instead, she put it in her pocket and walked home.

That evening, Nora did not call Adam back.

She wrote to Maya instead.

Still okay for tomorrow?

Maya answered:

Yes. 4 p.m. And Nora?

Yes?

Come as yourself. Not as an apology with legs.

Nora stared at the message.

Then laughed.

Then cried.

Then typed:

I hate how everyone knows me.

Maya replied:

We love you. We have data.

Nora wiped her face.

Adam did not call again.

That hurt.

It also helped.

She hated that too.

The next day, Nora arrived at the hospital at 3:52.

Eight minutes early.

She stood outside the entrance with a small paper bag in one hand. Inside were pears, because Maya had said Tomas hated them, and Nora had panicked at a fruit stand and bought the wrong thing on purpose, hoping humor might do what sincerity sometimes failed to do.

Maya met her near the sliding doors.

She looked tired but steadier than she had the night before.

“Are those pears?” Maya asked.

“Yes.”

“My father hates pears.”

“I know.”

Maya stared.

Then she laughed, really laughed, bending slightly as if the sound surprised her. The laugh opened something in Nora’s chest.

“Okay,” Maya said, wiping one eye. “That is exactly stupid enough to work.”

Inside, the hospital swallowed them.

The air changed first. It always did. Hospitals smelled like antiseptic, coffee, plastic, and waiting. Nora’s body remembered things that had not happened to her directly. Maya’s memory through borrowed skin. Adam’s. Daniel the cashier. Anna.

She stopped walking.

Maya stopped too.

“Pressure?”

“No,” Nora said. “Memory.”

“Yours?”

Nora swallowed. “Some mine. Some not.”

Maya looked at her for a moment.

Then she said, “We can leave.”

“No.”

“Nora.”

“I’m okay.” Nora looked at her. “Not perfectly. But enough.”

Maya accepted that.

They took the elevator to the fourth floor. A man stood in the corner holding flowers. A woman in scrubs leaned against the rail with her eyes closed. An old couple held hands without speaking.

So many lives pressed into one small moving box.

Nora fixed her eyes on the floor numbers.

Two.

Three.

Four.

No doors opened inside her.

Maya led her down a hallway to a room with the door half open.

Before they entered, Maya touched Nora’s arm.

“My mother is there,” she said. “She knows you know. Not about the jumps. About the cancer.”

“Okay.”

“She may cry.”

“Okay.”

“She may feed you.”

“In the hospital?”

“She carries crackers.”

“Of course she does.”

Maya gave her a grateful look.

Then they went in.

Tomas Santos was sitting upright in bed, wearing a blue hospital gown and an expression of deep personal offense. He was thinner than Nora remembered from the last time she had seen him, at Maya’s birthday dinner two years ago, but his eyes were sharp.

Beside him sat Maya’s mother, Lucia, small and elegant, holding a tissue in one hand and, somehow, a packet of crackers in the other.

Tomas looked at Nora.

“So,” he said. “You came.”

Nora lifted the paper bag. “I brought pears.”

Silence.

Maya covered her mouth.

Lucia looked confused.

Tomas stared at the bag as if it had insulted his ancestors.

Then he laughed.

The laugh became a cough, and the cough made Lucia stand too fast, but Tomas waved her down.

“This one,” he said to Maya, still coughing lightly, “is disrespectful.”

“She learned from you,” Maya said.

Nora set the pears on the small table near the bed. “I was told you hate them.”

“Hate is too soft. Pears are apples that gave up.”

Nora smiled.

The room eased.

Not fully.

But enough.

Lucia hugged Nora longer than Nora expected. “Thank you for coming,” she whispered.

Nora hugged her back carefully.

No pressure.

No pull.

Only a woman tired from loving someone through illness.

For the next twenty minutes, they talked about ordinary things. Tomas complained about hospital soup. Lucia corrected his exaggerations. Maya sat near the bed, visibly relieved to have someone else absorbing a corner of the room’s fear. Nora mostly listened.

She asked no medical questions.

When a doctor came in to check something on the chart, Nora looked at Maya instead of the papers.

Maya noticed.

Later, Tomas pointed at the pears. “Give me one.”

Maya blinked. “You hate pears.”

“I want to judge this specific pear.”

Nora handed him one.

He turned it in his hand, suspicious.

“You know,” he said, “Maya talks about you like you are her sister.”

Nora’s throat tightened.

Maya looked down.

“She is my sister,” Nora said.

Tomas studied her.

“Then do not make my daughter carry you while she is carrying me.”

The room went still.

Maya’s head lifted. “Dad.”

“No.” Tomas’s voice was weak but firm. “I am sick, not blind.”

Nora could not breathe.

Lucia looked away, embarrassed and pained.

Tomas continued, “Maya loves like her mother. Quietly breaking her own bones to make shelter for other people.”

Lucia whispered, “Tomas.”

“It is true.” He looked back at Nora. “If you are her sister, stand beside her. Do not climb onto her back.”

The words entered Nora cleanly.

Not cruel.

Not soft.

Given.

A hard gift.

“I’m trying,” Nora said.

Tomas nodded once. “Good. Try harder.”

Maya let out a wet, horrified laugh. “Dad.”

“What? She brought pears. She can survive honesty.”

Nora laughed too, though her eyes burned.

“I deserved that.”

Tomas lifted the pear. “Yes. And this pear deserves nothing.”

The room breathed again.

But the sentence stayed with Nora.

Do not climb onto her back.

When visiting time ended, Lucia hugged Nora again. Tomas told her to take the pears away before they infected the room. Maya walked Nora to the elevator.

Neither spoke until the doors closed around them.

Then Maya leaned against the wall and covered her face.

Nora’s chest clenched. “Are you angry?”

Maya lowered her hands.

She was crying, but smiling too.

“No,” she said. “I think I needed him to say it.”

“I’m sorry.”

“I know.”

“No, I mean—”

“Nora.” Maya took her hand. “I know.”

The elevator descended.

Three.

Two.

One.

Maya squeezed her fingers.

“You did good today,” she said.

Nora closed her eyes.

“Don’t grade me.”

“I am absolutely grading you.”

“What did I get?”

“A minus.”

Nora opened one eye. “For what?”

“You brought pears into a hospital room.”

“He laughed.”

“He coughed.”

“He laughed first.”

Maya smiled.

The elevator doors opened.

In the lobby, people moved in every direction, carrying flowers, forms, coffee, fear.

Nora felt all of it at the edges.

But only at the edges.

Maya walked beside her.

As they reached the exit, Nora’s phone buzzed.

Adam.

This time, she answered.

“Hi,” she said.

There was a pause.

Then Adam’s voice, careful. “Hi.”

“I’m sorry I hung up yesterday.”

“I’m sorry I made concern sound like judgment.”

Nora looked at Maya, who pretended not to listen while listening completely.

“You were partly right,” Nora said.

Adam exhaled. “I know. That’s my least charming category.”

Nora laughed softly.

“I went as myself,” she said.

“I’m glad.”

“Tomas told me not to climb onto Maya’s back.”

Adam was quiet.

Then, with great seriousness, “I like him.”

“He also said pears are apples that gave up.”

“I love him.”

Maya leaned close enough to say into the phone, “He hates you too, Adam.”

Adam laughed.

The sound was warm, relieved, and tired.

Nora stepped out of the hospital into cold evening air. Maya beside her. Adam in her ear. The sky above them bruised purple and gold.

For once, Nora had entered a room she had been invited into.

She had seen pain.

She had stayed herself.

And when she left, she carried something heavy but clean.

Not stolen.

Given.

Not a door forced open.

A chair pulled gently beside a bed.

It was not healing.

Not yet.

But it was a different kind of beginning.

DaintyHub